



Sports Desk

By JOE DIETZ

Now, about those Giants, Horace

Dear Horace Stoneham: I am just cruel enough to want to know how you are feeling these days.

I feel I have the right to ask because I have been a Giant fan exactly 43 years, ever since somebody gave me a baseball shirt and I had Mom sew a big "G" on the left side, ever since my father used to take me to the Polo Grounds from our home 75 miles up the Hudson to see young geniuses like Freddy Lindstrom and Mel Ott—yeah, even Andy Cohen—while the tar out of everybody else in the league.

I hung on through the full years and the lean years to the era of Willie Mays, Alvin Dark, Bobby Thomson, Mandrake Mueller. Even when you, a guy who doesn't particular need money like most of the guys who paid to see your team play day after day at Coogan's Bluff, packed up the uniforms and the players and the baggage and departed for the West Coast.

When that happened, I said, what the heck, a guy has to have some team to root for and no self respecting Giant fan could go for the Yankees although your kids and their friends, weaned in the years of Joe McCarthy and Casey Stengel, hooted in derision every time you showed your face on the front stoop.

So I said to myself, New York Giants-San Francisco Giants, what difference does it really make? They're still THE Giants, the Giants of John McGraw and your father, the Giants of Bill Terry and Lindstrom, Ott, Travis Jackson and all the rest. Three thousand miles away in Newark, we were still going for you.

We figured it something like this: Out in San Francisco, there would be more money, there would be better players and better managers. That would mean more pennants and world championships and for a fan there is nothing like having your team win them all—just like right now the guys in the office from Forty Fort, Pa., Mauch Chunk, Pa., and Johnstown, Pa., are giving it the old heart and soul for the Pittsburgh Pirates, like the baseball fans in Carteret and Secaucus who have followed the St. Louis Cardinals with a blind faith for 30 years are saying their beads for Solly Hemus.

Willie was still with us

So we figured maybe San Francisco would be good for the Giants. You still had Willie Mays, and for old Giant fans like myself, he's got to be the greatest of them all. And you came up with some new fellows who aroused in us old guys something of a false hope. One year it was Orlando Cepeda; last year it was Willie McCovey. And you traded away some pretty good stuff for Don Blasingame, Sam Jones, Billy O'Dell and the rest of the new faces.

Last spring we tried to be realistic after the way our club folded in the 1959 stretch giving the Dodgers a chance to fight their way into the World Series after a playoff against the Braves.

We figured the Dodgers would be back with the same club that looked so great in late 1959 and would come up with some new guys like Frank Howard to knock your brains out. We figured also that McCovey, who put the Giants back in business last July, maybe was just a flash in the pan and maybe the grinding years would catch up on guys like Antonelli and Jones.

But what's the use of saying this might happen or that might happen? The fact is that something did happen and while maybe it's not your fault, you didn't help things. When the Giants were only a few games out of first place you got panicky and fired the manager, Bill Rigney. Maybe he wasn't the greatest, but everybody felt that he was the best you had and you should go along with him right down the stretch. It kinda inspires a manager to know his boss is with him 100 per cent.

Clancy got the job

But you fired Rigney and appointed your chief scout, Clancy Sheehan, in his place, a guy who through the years has brought up some pretty good ballplayers. He is also the same old pal who has been telling you for years what Durocher did wrong and what Rigney did wrong and intimating that a guy named Clancy Sheehan could do much better.

Well, when you fired Rigney, the Giants were only a few games out of first place. This morning they are 14½. Heading the second division with Pittsburgh, St. Louis, the Dodgers and Braves ahead of them. Your old fans think they can even go down deeper in the standings.

So now, what do we hear? Maybe next year Durocher—the guy who quit the team cold back in 1955—or Jackie Robinson will be running our team. Let me tell you, Horace, if that happens, it won't be our team any longer. There are a few things that even the most loyal Giant fan can't take.